CULTURE

Dance of the Divine

Mudra, the NCPA's annual dance festival, is back in April, with some of India's best dancers interpreting the theme of 'aharya', the aesthetics of Indian classical dance

The excitement currently whirling around the corridors of Mumbai's National Centre for the Performing Arts (NCPA) is palpable. Its focal point is their annual dance festival, Mudra 2025, which began on April 3 and will continue until April 29. This year's Mudra features over 100 performers, including accompanying musicians. Audiences are being treated to performances of classical dances such as Bharatanatyam, Odissi, Kathak and Kuchipudi, as well as folk dances at multiple venues across the NCPA.

Dr Swapnokalpa Dasgupta, who has been head of the dance department at the NCPA since 2013, explains how Mudra is a thematic festival rather than simply a dance showcase. "Our themes are intentionally thought-provoking, encouraging artistes to reflect on aspects they might not otherwise consider," she shares. This year's theme is 'aharya', which, she says, plays a very integral role in 'abhinaya', or acting, within Indian classical dance and aesthetics, as described in the *Natyashastra*.

ALONG WITH PERFORMANCES, MUDRA INCLUDES DANCE SKETCHES AND DANCESCAPES BY ARTISTE SUBODH PODDAR

"Aharya creates the crucial first impression before movement or music begins. This is why I've included an exhibition by photographer Avinash Pasricha," explains Dasgupta. Additionally, the exhibition includes dance sketches and dancescapes by the renowned artiste Subodh Poddar, which creatively depict the movement and serve as a visual explora-

SHAILESH MULE



JOYOUS STEPS
An NCPA production, *Nrityavani* being performed; inset, Swapnokalpa Dasgupta, head of the dance department at NCPA